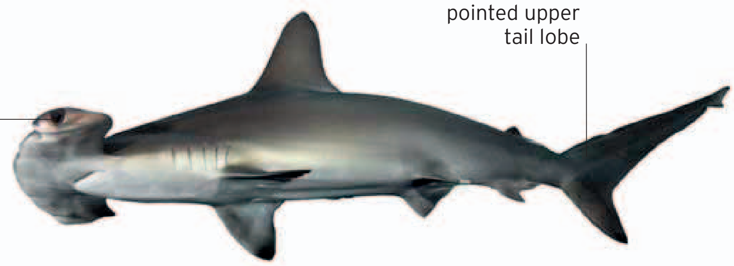

Scalloped hammerhead shark

Sphyrna lewini

There are few fish as iconic as a hammerhead shark, and the scalloped hammerhead is one of the most widespread. Contrary to their reputations as lone killers, these sharks are highly social—at least the females are. Groups develop around older, dominant females, with the lowest ranked individuals out on the edge. Hammerhead sharks display dominance by swimming in a corkscrew or ramming each other. Weaker individuals submit with a shake of the head.

Love bite

Male scalloped hammerheads reach maturity at the age of six—a full 10 years before the females, which are normally 7 ft (2 m) long before they are ready to breed. A mature male swims into the school of females, sweeping toward the center in an S-shaped path. When he meets a likely mate, he secures himself to her by biting on one of her pectoral fins. Scalloped hammerheads give birth to live young and about 25 pups are born after an 8–12 month gestation.

At birth, the pups are only 16 in (40 cm) long, but fully formed with the distinctive hammerhead. They receive no parental care and have to fend for themselves. Most hunting takes place at night, with younger scalloped hammerheads feeding in shallow water, while the older ones move further out to sea.

The hammer feature has benefits in both habitats. The wide head acts like a hydrofoil—an underwater wing that creates lift, keeping the shark afloat. The head also acts as a communication dish, allowing the shark's senses to work better.

Prey detector

Hammerheads, like other sharks, have an excellent sense of smell. They can detect tiny quantities of chemicals in the water with two nostril-like slots called nares, which are located toward the ends of the hammer just in front of the eyes. The large distance between the nares means that a scent coming from a particular direction arrives at each nare at different times. This allows the hammerhead to zero in on the exact source of the scent.

Tiny pits arrayed along the underside of the hammerhead are filled with electrical sensors called the ampullae of Lorenzini. The large scanning surface provided by the head greatly enhances the sensitivity of these sensors, which can detect very tiny electrical currents produced by the nerves and muscles of all animals. By sweeping its head over the seabed like a metal detector, the hammerhead locates prey buried in the sand and takes hold of it, sometimes pinning it down with its head.

Scalloped hammerheads' **teeth** are more **suited to seize prey** than to rip it apart

- 5–7 ft (1.4–2.1 m)
- 64–175 lb (29–80 kg)
- Endangered
- Fish, squid, crustaceans

Tropical and temperate waters worldwide